

in Aramaic: "Then Darius the king arose, and kissed him;" and it was continued *in Hebrew*: "And he wrote letters for him unto all the administrators and governors," etc.

The result of this investigation has been, to restore a lost half-chapter to our "canonical" Old Testament—a thing which has never been done before, and presumably will never be done again—and to give the Story of the Three Youths its true place as an important specimen of old Aramaic literature. I hope to throw further light on the origin of this Story in a subsequent chapter.

IV. THE ORIGIN OF OUR TWO RECENSIONS

The Chronicler, probably not far from the middle of the third century B. C., but possibly later, wrote his Levitical History of Israel. Its contents, in their original order, were as follows: I and II Chronicles; Ezr. 1; *I Esdr.* 4:47-56; 4:62-5:6; Ezr. 2:1-8:36; *Neh.* 7:70-8:18; Ezr. 9:1-10:44; *Neh.* 9:1-10:40; *Neh.* 1:1-7:69; 11:1-13:31.

At the beginning of the last century B. C. this history was current only in a form which differed from the original form in two important particulars: (1) Three chapters originally belonging to the story of Ezra had been accidentally transposed, by a natural mistake,¹⁴ into the book of Nehemiah. (2) The Aramaic Story of the Three Youths had been interpolated. The interpolator added a few harmonistic verses at the end of the Story, and also *transposed the passage Ezra 4:6-24* to a place just before it.

Somewhat later, still another alteration found its way into numerous copies of the work. The fact that the account of *the reading of the Law* (*Neh.* 7:73-8:18), and that of *the sealing of the covenant* (*Neh.* 9:1-10:40), had originally belonged to the story of Ezra was not lost sight of among the Jews. Accordingly, someone, at some time in the last century B. C., made an attempt to restore the history to its true form by transposing these chapters to the place from which they were supposed to have come. That is, they were simply appended to the story of Ezra, being made to follow Ezra 10. It must be noted, however, that *not all* of the matter which had originally belonged to the story of Ezra was restored at this time. The three verses *Neh.* 7:70-72 were so securely lodged in their new surroundings (owing to the same considera-

¹⁴See my *Composition of Ezr.-Neh.*, p. 34.